

The Star

Largest Circulation of Any Evening Paper in the Kingdom

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The Star sold 126,000 copies on its first day, 17 January 1888, a world record that confirmed the founder's belief in the demand for a radical evening newspaper. A four-page broadsheet, published six days a week, it cost a halfpenny.

The front-page editorial expounded its cause: "The rich, the privileged, the prosperous need no guardian or advocate; the poor, the weak, the beaten require the work and word of every humane man and woman to stand between them and the world."

Thomas Power O'Connor (1848–1929) was the founder and first editor of the Star. An Irish Nationalist MP and journalist, he represented Liverpool Scotland Division from 1885 until his death. He is the only British MP from an Irish nationalist party ever elected to a constituency outside Ireland.

The Star's first year coincided with two major stories: the Whitechapel murders of 1888 and what the paper called "the Times Conspiracy", a campaign to discredit Charles Stewart Parnell, leader of the Irish Parliamentary Party.

A Special Commission opened on 17 September 1888 to investigate allegations based on letters published by The Times. Over the next 16 months, judges sat for 128 sessions, questioning 445 witnesses. Parnell was proved innocent. The Times admitted the letters were forgeries, and Piggott, who supplied them, was later found dead in Madrid. "Nothing can add to the disgust and reprobation with which the conduct of the Times is regarded by all decent and honest men," raged the Star.

Ernest Parke became editor in 1889, and George Bernard Shaw was a regular contributor. "Mainly About People", "Notes of the Day" and "What We Think" were popular features. By summer 1895, The Star was selling 150,000 copies daily.

The Star was one of the few papers to oppose the Boer War. Although circulation suffered, the paper was later vindicated for its stand.



WHAT WE THINK

There are two subjects which we must let drop in Parliament. We must raise the again and again until we have brought Government to bay upon them. The one the share of the Ministers in the Times of spiny; the other is the treatment of political prisoners. With regard to first there is a natural inclination go for the ATTORNEY-GENERAL, especially in view of the dining facts we set forth on Saturday reference to his connection with the case. If some people think—and, perhaps, they right—that we should wait until we have fore the House of Commons the report we regard to these letters which the Judges probably give in a few days. We cannot think that their lordships will require much time prepare the document on this particular point. The evidence as to the forgery of the letters of course, is now clear beyond the possibility of doubt; and to set forth that fact will require any great length of words. We should hope it would seem good to Sir JAMES HANNA and his colleagues to spread some rumour.

Mr Gladstone proposed his Home Rule Bill in 1910. Interviewed in 1912, TP O'Connor said that was when the Star really came into its own.

In December 1913 the paper was enlarged to eight pages and the following month to twelve. But in 1914 came the Great War and censorship. Like all newspapers, the Star had to be submitted to the Press Bureau before publication. Newsprint was rationed, and by 1916 the paper was reduced to four pages. In January 1918, rising paper costs forced the price up from a halfpenny to a penny.

By 1926 the 16-page Star had been taken over by Cadbury's, owners of the Daily News. The paper moved from Stonecutter Street to Tudor and Bouverie Street.

Even the General Strike of 1926 could not check the paper's steady growth. On 15 November 1926 it expanded to 20 pages, including two pages of news pictures, a first for a London evening newspaper.

In 1932 the paper campaigned against the 33% tax on insulin. The duty was removed in 1934, and the Star's influence was acknowledged in the House of Commons.

On 30 June 1936 a bust of TP O'Connor was unveiled at Chronicle House, Fleet Street. The inscription read: "His pen could lay bare the bones of a book or the soul of a statesman in a few lines."

Jubilee celebrations at the Savoy Hotel marked the paper's 50th anniversary in 1938. But on 3 September 1939 Britain declared war on Germany, and the paper returned to four pages and censorship. Newsprint rationing continued until late 1958.

Despite paper restrictions, the Star achieved its greatest sales in the late 1940s. On 20 November 1947, the day Princess Elizabeth married Prince Philip, it sold 1,414,660 copies.

On 17 October 1960, the Star disappeared, along with its sister paper, the News Chronicle. Both papers and their Bouverie Street offices were secretly sold to the second Viscount Rothermere, and the Star was merged with the Evening News, a paper with the opposite political views.